

OPINION

My mother-in-law was brilliant, funny and kind. Plus she fought Nazis as a young woman.

Elly steadfastly refused to be defined by the vicissitudes that marked her early years.



● Opt-Out Signal Honored



Courtesy

Elfriede Klein Bog Wierda was born in the Netherlands in December 1922.



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There's an old saying that it's a mother-in-law's duty to make her son-in-law's life hard. In my case, nothing could be further from the truth.

Elfriede Klein Bog Wierda was born in the Netherlands in December 1922. A few months after turning 17, Elly saw her idyllic world be shattered when the German army invaded. As a result of the Dutch policy of neutrality, its armed forces were unprepared, outnumbered and ill-equipped. Over a brutal [five-day](#) campaign, 5,000 Dutch citizens were killed and more than 10,000 wounded. On May 15, 1940, the Netherlands officially surrendered.

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But Elly kept fighting. As part of the Dutch resistance, she assisted in collecting intelligence, distributing goods and food, and preparing for the Allied invasion. She also aided Jewish families in hiding downed Allied airmen and young Dutchmen who would otherwise be drafted into the Nazi army.

As a young, pretty woman, the resistance often called upon Elly to disguise clandestine activities. She would ride her bicycle into the countryside, obtain buried weapons and smuggle them back into Amsterdam. On one bike trip, she was surprised by a German transport. When she skidded to a stop, several hidden guns clattered onto the road. Only good fortune prevented her immediate arrest and execution: Before the Germans spotted the weapons, another cyclist intentionally fell from his bike to cover them with his body.

Not all of Elly's friends and family were so lucky. Her fiancé — another resistance fighter — was killed by a German sniper in Amsterdam as the fiancé was walking arm-in-arm with Elly. Her older brother, the head of the resistance at Leiden University, was sent to a forced labor camp. After escaping, he joined the British Army but was killed days later during the Allied invasion of Germany. In total, more than 200,000 Dutch men and women were killed during the war, including some of her close friends and family.

After the Nazis' surrender in 1945, Elly (who spoke seven languages) traveled to Germany seeking looted Dutch art, such as a Vermeer taken by Reichsmarschall Hermann Göring. Thanks in part to her work there, Han van Meegeren, an artist who made millions of dollars forging paintings of Vermeer and other Dutch masters, was arrested and convicted.

In 1948, Elly married Don Wierda, a shipping executive and decorated United States veteran who was living in Holland. They moved to the United States in 1955 with their young family (including her daughter Marcia, who I was eventually fortunate enough to marry).

Elly was brilliant, funny, kind and generous. She possessed a rare Old World charm and cultured civility, but could also be combative and playful when interacting with others. Most importantly, she steadfastly refused to be defined by the vicissitudes that marked her early years. She remained a friend to all people, regardless of income or background. Elly died in 2011

Elly's early life was marred by great tragedy, but she spent the rest of it making life easier and more joyful for everyone else — including her son-in-law.

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